Crop rotation & planning

Across the years

Rotation means moving a crop to different ground instead of planting it in the same place year after year. Its most useful job in a small garden is to reduce the build-up of problems shared by related plants.

One bed, three different families



An example of changing families, not a compulsory three-year prescription.

Four beds, four years

The traditional four-block plan moves peas and beans, brassicas, potatoes, then onions and other roots through the same ground. Here is one way to arrange it. Read down a bed's column to follow its crops; the beds themselves stay put.

Year	Bed A	Bed B	Bed C	Bed D
1	Peas & beans	Brassicas	Potatoes	Onions & roots
2	Brassicas	Potatoes	Onions & roots	Peas & beans
3	Potatoes	Onions & roots	Peas & beans	Brassicas
4	Onions & roots	Peas & beans	Brassicas	Potatoes

These are practical groups, not four botanical families. Keep radishes, swedes and turnips with the brassicas, not the other roots. Use the family table opposite to place other crops.

Fit the plan to your appetite

A flexible core rotation need not use the standard four blocks seen in old gardening manuals. A larger number of small beds or areas inside beds gives you flexibility. Keep permanent crops, such as asparagus and rhubarb, outside the annual shuffle.

John: Raised Beds and rotation notes. Original three-year example retained; four-block sequence also shown by RHS.

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Within the year

A bed can carry more than one crop in a year. Plan when the first crop will finish as well as what follows it. The replacement must be ready while there is still time for it to grow.

One bed, two crops in the same year



Broad beans
Legumes

→



Kale
Brassicas

After early broad beans, use the bed for kale. Sow kale separately in June or early July; plant promptly when ready, often July or early August. Choose a suitable variety, allow time before winter and protect seedlings from pests. Record both families. See Kale, pages 40–41.

Crop families: useful examples

Brassicas	Cabbage, kale, broccoli, Brussels sprouts, cauliflower, kohlrabi, radish, swede and turnip
Alliums	Onion, shallot, leek and garlic
Legumes	Peas and beans
Potato family	Potatoes, tomatoes, aubergines, peppers and chillies
Carrot family	Carrot, parsnip, celery, celeriac, Florence fennel, coriander and dill
Beet family	Beetroot, spinach and leaf beet (chard)
Cucumber family	Cucumber, courgette, marrow, pumpkin and squash
Lettuce family	Lettuce, chicory and endive

Keep a simple record

Sketch your beds and write down what grew where, including a second crop in the same year. Next season, move the main crop to ground that held an unrelated family. Changing cabbage for broccoli does not count: they share too many problems.

A rotation is not a disease cure

Clubroot and onion white rot can remain in soil for many years. A short circuit round the beds does not make infected ground clean. Use the Troubles guides for the diagnosed problem, keep contaminated soil off clean beds, and do not put infected allium debris into good compost.

John: Raised Beds and rotation notes. Crop and Troubles JSON; Garden Organic and University of Saskatchewan family tables.

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Grow what you'll use

Start with what your household eats. Use your usual shopping as a guide, then separate fresh picking from crops you can store. A few useful crops grown well are a better starting point than a long list with no room to grow them.

A family's winter carrots

Suppose a family of four wants about 26 lb of carrots for twelve weeks of winter use. That is their chosen amount, not an allowance per person. Use the guide's maincrop yield to estimate the space.

WANTED FOR STORAGE	GUIDE YIELD	ALLOW THREE ROWS
About 26 lb	**10 lb**	**3 × 10 ft rows**
for twelve weeks	per 10 ft row	about 30 lb

This gives a little spare capacity, not a guaranteed harvest. Keep the guide's plant and row spacing. Weigh what you actually harvest and note storage losses, then adjust next year's plan.

Store only sound roots in dry sand, without touching, in a cool, ventilated place just above freezing, and inspect for rot. See Carrot, pages 14–15.

Make a small plot work harder

Climbing French beans use height and can crop for longer than dwarf beans when kept picked and watered. Put supports where they will not shade crops which need full sun, and leave room to reach, water and pick them.

Use the calendar as well as the bed plan. Small repeated sowings of salads spread the harvest; a suitable second crop can use ground after an early one. Follow each crop's sowing window and spacing. More plants squeezed in does not necessarily mean more food.

Grow some beans for winter

Plant extra French beans for winter meals. A variety such as Blue Lake white-seeded provides young summer pods and dry haricot beans. Reserve part of the crop to mature, so the surplus is useful beyond summer.

Let pods ripen and turn straw-coloured. If necessary, hang the plants in an airy shed; shell and dry the beans fully before airtight storage. Watch for wet weather and mould. Keep the bed allocated until maturity, rather than planning an early changeover. See French beans, pages 44–45.

Before eating dried beans

Soak for 6–12 hours until softened, discard the water, then boil in fresh water at 212°F for at least 30 minutes and until soft. Undercooked beans can make you ill.

Crop JSON; John's plot-planning notes and September 2026 bean-drying video. Household target is illustrative; cooking: EFSA, 2026.

Sowing and planting A sound start

The crop guide gives you the season and method. Your weather and soil decide whether today is a sensible day to begin. In cold or wet weather, delay planting. A head start only helps if the plants keep growing.



Sow directly, or raise plants separately. Harden indoor-raised plants before planting out.

Direct into the bed

Prepare a fine, firm surface and remove competing weeds. Make a drill (a shallow groove) at the depth given for the crop; water it first if dry. Sow, cover and firm gently, then keep the seed zone moist. On coarse no-dig compost, use a little sieved compost in the drill and over the seed.

Start under cover

Modules are the separate cells in a seed tray. In a greenhouse or on a windowsill, they give early crops a start while outside soil is still cold. Sow at the crop's depth, label with variety and date, and give the seedlings light and steady moisture. Use modules early in the year; later, a small outdoor nursery bed is often easier than nursing young outdoor crops through a hot greenhouse.

Plant them out

Harden indoor-raised plants gradually: put them outside in a sheltered spot by day and return them under cover at night, increasing exposure over two to three weeks. Keep tender crops from frost. Water before lifting, preserve the roots, and plant at the crop's stated depth and spacing. Firm gently and water in.

A small experiment: mixed salad leaves

For an odd corner, try broadcasting mixed salad seed. Choose crops with compatible sowing times, covering depths and picking sizes. Scatter evenly, cover as required and water gently. Thin before the strongest swamp the rest, and keep a separate main sowing of any crop you are relying on.

A station is one sowing or planting position. Sow little and often where the crop allows it. Check each guide's method and depth; carrots, lettuces and peas do not start in the same way.

John: No-dig sowing, module notes and Chuck It Around. Crop JSON; RHS hardening off.